



The Amazon Rainforest

Earth's largest tropical rain forest, home to 390 billion trees and 2.5 million insect species

Covering an area of almost 2 million square miles (6 million square km), the Amazon is the world's largest tropical rain forest, situated within the planet's biggest river drainage basin. The bulk of the rain forest is located in northern Brazil, but parts extend into eight other South American countries. Rainfall is high—as much as 120 in (3,000 mm) per year—with humidity averaging over 80 percent, and temperatures rarely falling below 79°F (26°C).

This constantly moist, warm environment hosts an incredibly rich ecosystem, where an estimated 16,000 tree species coexist alongside 1,300 bird species and a staggering 2.5 million insect species. Scientists believe even more species have yet to be discovered. However, deforestation, due mainly to cattle ranching and agriculture, remains a huge threat to the Amazon Rain forest. From 1970 to 2016, 296,887 square miles (768,935 square km), or roughly 20 percent, of the Brazilian rain forest was destroyed.

More than **half** of the world's species live in tropical rain forests



◀ **CANOPY FEEDING**
Many rain forest plants depend on animals to disperse their seeds. The scarlet macaw spreads seeds of the açaí palm by eating its fruit.

Kapok
This giant of the rain forest towers above the canopy, reaching heights of up to 60 m (200 ft). Kapok flowers are pollinated by bats.

► RAIN FOREST DYNAMICS

A tropical rain forest is both highly structured and densely populated—300 species of woody plant species can be found in just 2½ acres (1 hectare). The many species of plants and animals interact with and depend on each other to survive.

Açaí palm

A slender palm of the canopy layer, the açaí grows up to 50-100 ft (15-30 m) tall.



Ground level habitat

Larger animals search the forest floor for food. Vines growing from the floor create "highways" to upper layers.

Fallen tree

If an old tree falls over, it creates a gap in the canopy, allowing in sunlight. Nearby trees undergo a growth surge.

TROPICAL RAIN FOREST LAYERS

Tropical rain forests grow in five main layers. The forest floor is the hottest, darkest, and most humid. Small shrub-layer plants come next, competing for light and food. In the understory, ferns and vines grow over taller trees, where most birds nest. Eighty percent of rain forest life lives in the hot, dry canopy at heights of around 100 ft (30 m). Only the tops of the tallest trees, the emergents, project above it.

